

AURORA & SILENCE

The Kittila Village Tourism Co-operative - a case study

1. Background

The village of Alakittila (pop. 214) in Finnish Lapland formed a tourism co-operative in 2019. Eleven households are members. The co-op owns six guest cabins, a small smoke sauna by the lake, and a shared kitchen building, and it part-owns a husky farm with 28 dogs together with a neighbouring village. Total tourism revenue last year was 410,000 euros, of which 96 percent was earned between December and March.

2. The occupancy problem

Cabin occupancy by season (last full year):

December - March:	92 percent
April - May:	14 percent
June - August:	31 percent
September - November:	22 percent

The co-op chair, Marja-Leena K., summarised the board's view at the spring meeting: "We don't need more February. February is full. We need May. We need a reason for anyone to be here in May."

3. Stakeholder voices

The husky farm partner, Pekka R., is under growing pressure: "Every winter there are more articles about sled-dog welfare. We do things properly, but nobody visits a kennel to check. We are one bad article away from closing, and the whole village's winter product goes with us."

A young returnee, Sanna V. (28), moved back from Rovaniemi to work the winter season: "There is work here from December to March, and then there is nothing. If the co-op cannot give me a summer, I will have to leave again, and I am not the only one."

A member household that rents out two of the six cabins worries about scale: "We joined so that visitors would come to us, not so that we would become Levi. Whatever we build next must stay small enough that it is still our village."

4. Constraints

The co-operative's statute requires that at least 60 percent of all tourism revenue remains within the village (wages, purchases, rents). Any new product must respect this rule. The board has allocated up to 40,000 euros for developing ONE new product for the coming year.

The board has deliberately not decided what that product should be. That decision is the assignment.